

on a journey through the underworld. The car rolls across the screen, slowly, as though pulling up and asking the audience to step inside. On the sound track, the music swells and crashes. It's a moment of dread that tells the audience-as-passenger exactly where it's heading.

"You're in a hell," Travis tells Betsy

(Cybill Shepherd), a campaign volunteer he has fallen for, "and you're gonna die in a hell, just like the rest of 'em!" Hell is what he sees when he looks around him, and he wants to save her from the flames. She is an activist campaigning for "clean politics," and in her own way she, like Travis, is praying for rain. It is a sentiment that struck a chord with audiences at the time. When the movie was released in 1976, the Watergate scandal, in which President Nixon was exposed as a liar and removed from office, was still fresh in the national memory. Many Americans had lost their faith in politicians, and felt they were leaderless.

Finding a cause

Betsy, a beautiful and self-assured young blonde, rejects Travis after he takes her to a porn movie on their first date. Travis reacts badly, sending Betsy flowers afterward and harassing her at work, but then he turns his attention to another cause:

I know of nobody who can surprise me on the screen the way De Niro does... who can provide such power and excitement.

Martin Scorsese

a 12-year-old prostitute called Iris (Jodie Foster), who is every bit as confident as Betsy—and equally uninterested in being saved by Travis. But Travis gives her no choice in the matter.

Travis happens upon a hold up in a store and shoots the robber dead. The store owner covers for Travis, advising him to leave the scene because he does not have a gun licence. Travis sees that this killing, his first act of "cleansing," is gratefully received. Now he dons the combat

Travis, alone in his apartment, prepares for his day of action. He meticulously builds holsters for his guns and imagines talking to his victims as he looks at himself in the mirror.

